3 Minute Talk Activity

Warm Up

1. Ask for a volunteer (no explanation).
2. Have volunteer to come to the front of the room.
3. Tell him/her that he/she must talk non-stop for 3 minutes (classroom appropriate).
4. Instruct everyone else to sit quietly without interrupting the speaker.

After 3 minutes, discuss the activity.

Was it hard to talk for 3 minutes without feedback?	**(yes)**
Was it hard to not speak and say what came to mind for 3 minutes?	**(yes)**
Were we communicating with each other?	**(no)**

Introduction

Have you ever known someone who was really hard to communicate with?

Teacher gives real-life examples:

- Someone who thinks they are always right
- Someone who never listens
- Someone who never tries to see the other person's point of view

> Learning how to effectively communicate with others can build your self-confidence and help you to achieve your personal and professional goals.

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Back-to-Back Drawing

Directions: Pairs sit back to back. One person is the **Describer** and holds a picture card. The other is the **Drawer** and has blank paper and a pencil.

Describer
Holds the picture card and explains it in words.

Drawer
Has blank paper and a pencil, and draws what they hear.

HOW IT WORKS

1. **ROUND 1** The Describer explains the picture so the Drawer can copy it. No peeking, and no showing.
2. The Drawer stays silent the whole time: no questions, no nods, no "what?"
3. After 5 to 10 minutes, compare the drawing with the card.
4. **ROUND 2** Switch roles and use a new card. This time the Drawer may ask questions. Compare again.

TALK IT OVER

Describer

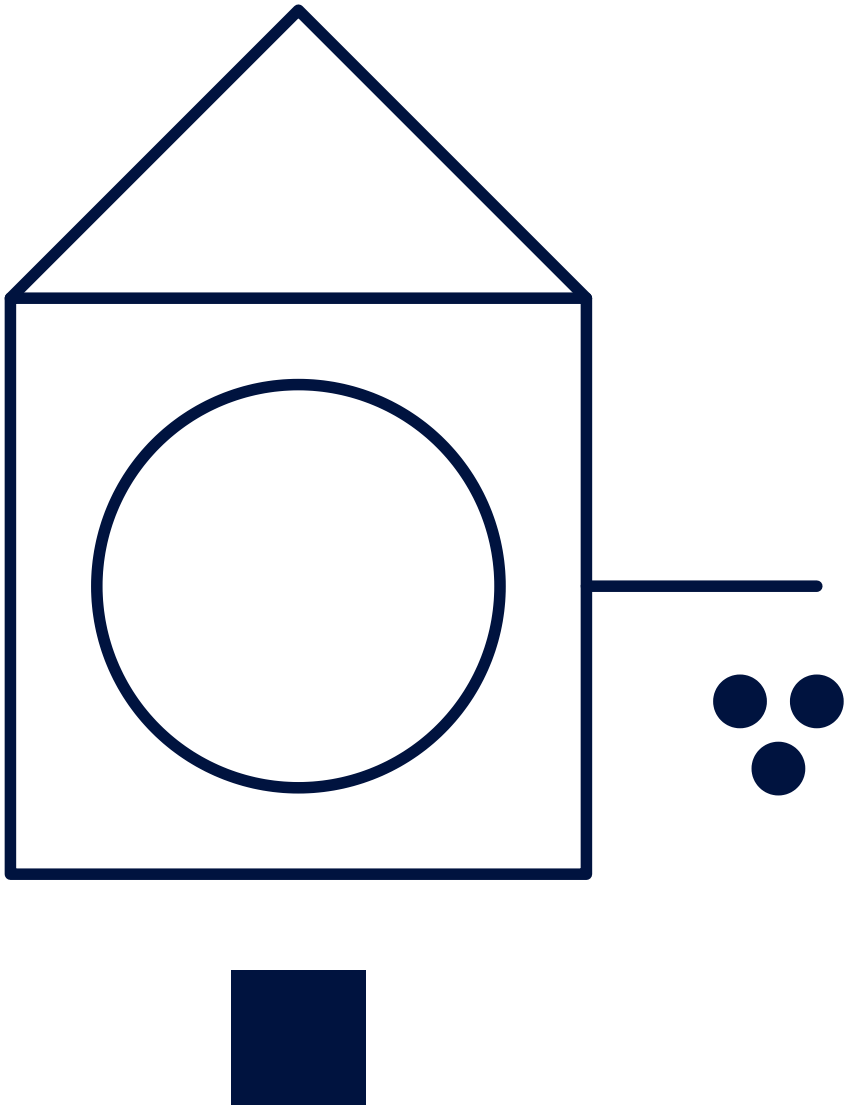
- What did you do to make your directions clear?
- How did it feel to get no response?
- What would you say differently next time?

Drawer

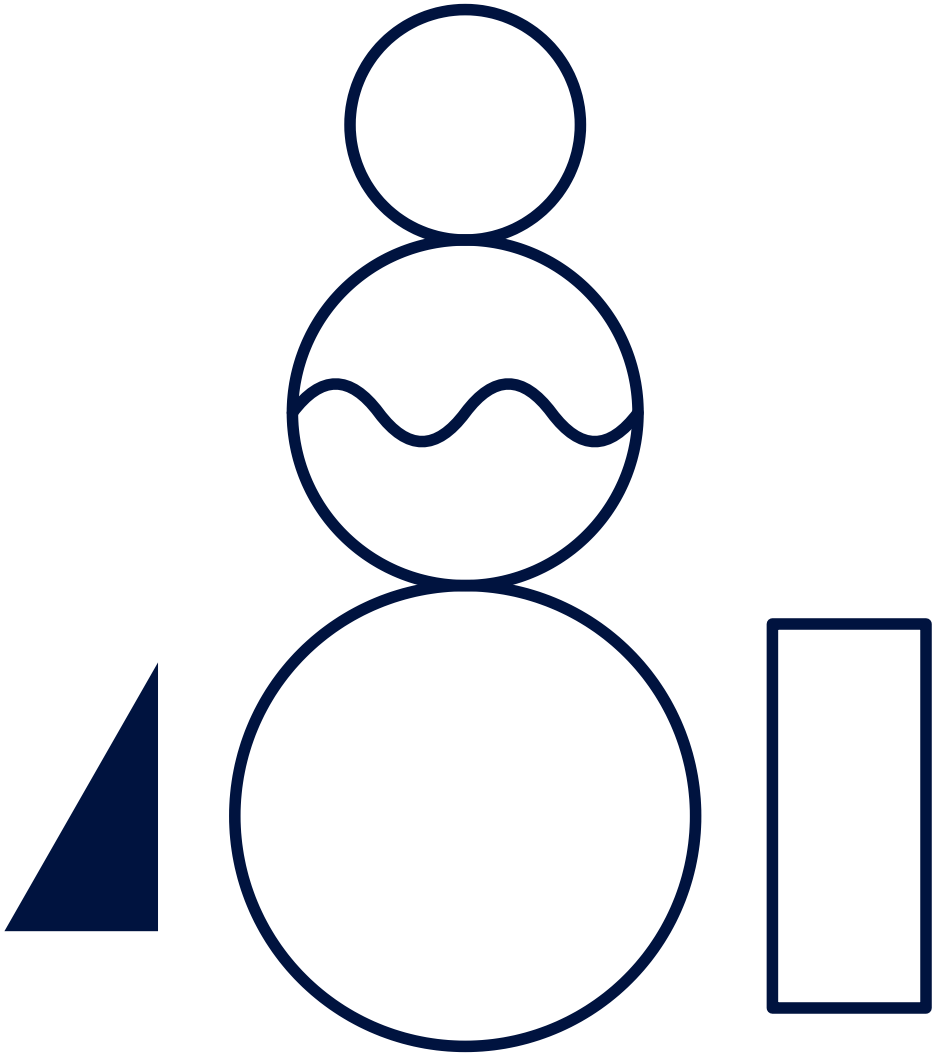
- Which directions were easy to follow, and which were confusing?
- How did round 2 change when you could ask questions?
- What does this tell you about listening at work?

Notes

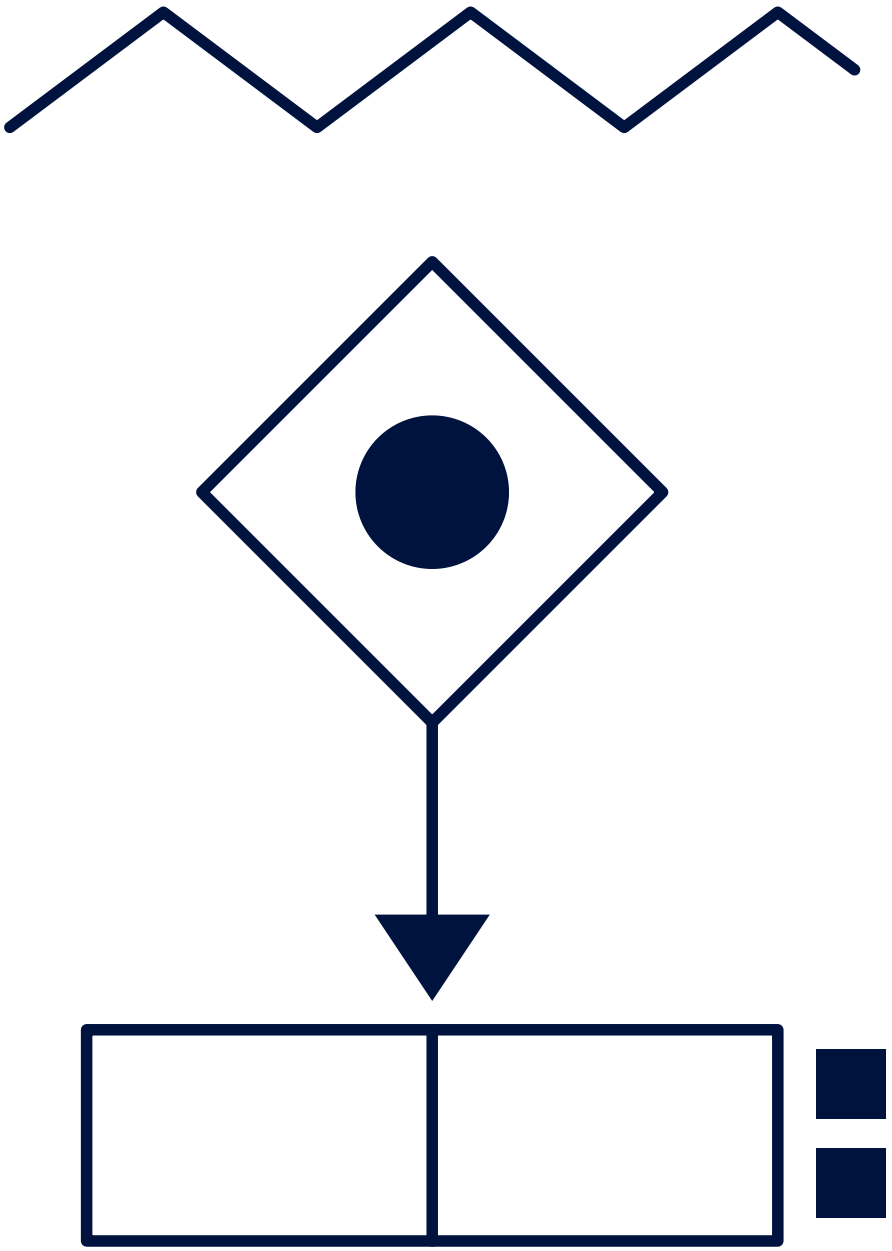
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Effective Communication Skills: Paper Fold Exercise

Purpose: This activity demonstrates what can go wrong in communication: poor listening, lack of feedback, different contexts/backgrounds and perceptions.

MATERIALS:
8 ½ sheet of paper for each person

TIME:
10 to 15 minutes plus discussion time

Directions: Lead into this exercise by asking folks if they think communication is easy. Tell them "let's see." Give each learner a piece of paper and then read the directions to them.

Instructions to participants: This exercise requires listening to and following directions. As you hear the instructions, perform the task. You may not ask questions. You must close your eyes.

1) Fold your sheet of paper in half
2) Tear off the upper right corner
3) Fold your paper in half again
4) Tear off the lower right corner
5) Fold your paper in half
6) Tear off the upper left corner
7) Fold in half a final time
8) Tear off the lower left corner
9) Unfold your paper and hold it up
10) Open your eyes, look at your product and compare it with the other student's

Debrief

What happened? Does everyone's look the same? Remember when you communicate with others, they may not receive the message you sent. Individual perceptions vary. If you were given the same directions, why are everyone's products different? People have different context. You were not given feedback…you had to keep your eyes closed and you could not ask questions.

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Connecting or Disconnecting?

How to play (2 or 3 players): Cut the cards apart and stack them face down.

1. Player 1 draws a card and reads it out loud.
2. Player 2 says whether it *connects* (brings people together) or *disconnects* (pushes them apart).
3. If Player 2 is right, they keep the card. If wrong, it goes to the bottom of the stack.
4. Switch roles. Play until the stack is gone.

ANSWER KEY: CHECK AFTER YOU PLAY

Connecting	Reason	Disconnecting	Reason
"I can see this matters to you."	*shows understanding*	**"Whatever. Do what you want."**	*brushes the person off*
"Can we figure this out together?"	*invites teamwork*	**"You never listen."**	*blames*
"I need a minute to think, then let's talk."	*asks for time*	**"That's not my problem."**	*refuses to help*
"Help me understand what happened."	*asks to understand*	**"Calm down!"**	*orders feelings*
"I was frustrated when the report was late."	*names the feeling and the facts*	**"Why would you do something so dumb?"**	*insults*
"Thanks for telling me."	*shows appreciation*	**"I'm done talking to you."**	*shuts the door*

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Cut along the dashed lines

“I can see this matters to you.” CARD 1	**“You never listen.”** CARD 2	**“Can we figure this out together?”** CARD 3
“Calm down!” CARD 4	**“I need a minute to think, then let’s talk.”** CARD 5	**“Whatever. Do what you want.”** CARD 6
“Help me understand what happened.” CARD 7	**“That’s not my problem.”** CARD 8	**“I was frustrated when the report was late.”** CARD 9
“Why would you do something so dumb?” CARD 10	**“Thanks for telling me.”** CARD 11	**“I’m done talking to you.”** CARD 12

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Personal Listening Assessment

Answer True or False to the following statements:

	Statements	Now T/F	Later T/F
1.	Many times errors happen not because of poor skills or performance but because of inadequate communication.		
2.	Listening comes naturally to everyone; we all know how to listen.		
3.	Listening and hearing are the same thing.		
4.	An effective communicator listens more than talks.		
5.	When someone is using effective listening skills they are focusing entirely on what is being said.		
6.	What you hear is usually what was stated.		
7.	When you are listening, you should just listen for the facts.		
8.	A friend or family member would say that your listening skills are above average.		
9.	Generally, you find yourself daydreaming when you try to listen.		
10.	Most of the time you find yourself pretending to listen.		
11.	You notice that you fidget a lot when trying to listen.		
12.	You recognize you only focus on the points of interest to you.		
13.	If you are listening to something you disagree with, you fold your arms and send a message that you have a different opinion.		
14.	You find that you frequently interrupt and finish peoples' thoughts and sentences.		
15.	You know you listen to part of the story, but then find yourself thinking about a story that will top the story being told (one upping the storyteller).		

Circle the word best describing the view of yourself as a listener:

Superior **Above Average** **Average** **Below Average** **Terrible**

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Communicating with the Public - Role-Play Scenarios

Purpose: Practice clear, empathetic, and accurate communication using real-world situations.

INSTRUCTIONS:

- Break into pairs, small groups, or large groups depending on class size.
- Assign roles: Communicator and Public.
- After each role-play, discuss:
  - Was the message clear?
  - Was the tone respectful?
  - Were questions answered accurately?

SCENARIO 1

Announcing a Community Event

Context: Your organization is hosting a free health fair next month.

Communicator Task: Explain event details and encourage participation.

Public Questions:

- *Is it really free?*
- *What services will be available?*
- *Do I need to register?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 2

Responding to a Complaint

Context: A resident is upset about a recent change in trash collection days.

Communicator Task: Respond calmly, explain the reason for the change, and offer solutions.

Public Questions:

- *Why wasn't I told?*
- *This is inconvenient for me!*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

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SCENARIO 3

Emergency Alert

Context: A severe storm is approaching, and you need to inform the public about safety measures.

Communicator Task: Deliver a clear, urgent message with instructions.

Public Questions:

- *Where can we go for shelter?*
- *How long will the storm last?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 4

Explaining a New Policy

Context: Your organization introduces a new recycling program.

Communicator Task: Explain the policy benefits and steps clearly.

Public Questions:

- *Why is this necessary?*
- *Will it cost us more?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 5

Handling Misinformation

Context: A rumor spreads that tap water is unsafe, but it's not true.

Communicator Task: Correct misinformation calmly and provide facts.

Public Questions:

- *I saw it online—how do I know you're telling the truth?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 6

Budget Announcement

Context: Your department announces a budget cut that affects community programs.

Communicator Task: Explain the reason for the cut and reassure the public about essential services.

Public Questions:

- *Will my program be canceled?*
- *Why are you cutting funding now?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 7

Public Safety Update

Context: A new traffic pattern is being implemented to reduce accidents.

Communicator Task: Explain the change and its benefits.

Public Questions:

- *Will this cause delays?*
- *How long will construction last?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 8

Responding to Negative Media Coverage

Context: A local news outlet reports inaccurate information about your organization.

Communicator Task: Address the misinformation professionally and restore trust.

Public Questions:

- *Is the report true?*
- *Why didn't you respond sooner?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

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SCENARIO 9

Promoting a New Service

Context: Your organization launches a new online payment system for utilities.

Communicator Task: Explain how to use it and its benefits.

Public Questions:

- *Is it secure?*
- *What if I don't have internet access?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

SCENARIO 10

Crisis Communication

Context: A chemical spill occurs near a residential area.

Communicator Task: Inform residents about safety precautions and evacuation plans.

Public Questions:

- *Is my family safe?*
- *When can we return home?*

Variations: 1-on-1, Small group, Large group

Facilitator Instructions

- Encourage participants to use plain language, empathy, and active listening.
- After each scenario, ask:
  - What worked well?
  - What could be improved?
- Reinforce clarity, respect, and accuracy as key principles.
- Allow time for feedback and discussion after each role-play.

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Role-Play Evaluation Form

Scenario: _____

Date: _____

Participants: _____

Evaluation Criteria (Rate 1–5):	1	2	3	4	5
Clarity of Message: Was the information easy to understand?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Tone and Professionalism: Was the tone respectful and appropriate?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Empathy and Active Listening: Did the communicator acknowledge concerns?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Accuracy of Information: Were facts correct and complete?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Confidence and Delivery: Was the communicator confident and calm?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Engagement: Did they encourage questions and interaction?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

Comments & Suggestions:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Overall Score: _____ **/ 30** **Facilitator Signature:** _____

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Role-Play Evaluation Form

Please use this form to evaluate the role-play scenario. Rate each criterion on a scale of 1 (Needs Improvement) to 5 (Excellent).

Scenario: _____

Date: _____

Participants: _____

Evaluation Criteria (Rate 1–5):	1	2	3	4	5
Clarity of Message: Was the information easy to understand?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Tone and Professionalism: Was the tone respectful and appropriate?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Empathy and Active Listening: Did the communicator acknowledge concerns?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Accuracy of Information: Were facts correct and complete?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Confidence and Delivery: Was the communicator confident and calm?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯
Engagement: Did they encourage questions and interaction?	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯

Comments & Suggestions:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Overall Score: _____ **/ 30** **Facilitator Signature:** _____

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Important Documents: Checklist and Where I Keep Them

Keep important papers together so you can find them fast when you apply for a job, benefits, housing or school. Check each one you have, write where you keep it, and circle any you need to replace.

✓	Document	Where I keep it
IDENTITY		
☐	Birth certificate	
☐	Social Security card	
☐	Passport	
☐	Driver's license or state ID	
☐	Marriage or divorce papers	
☐	Adoption papers	
☐	Immigration papers	
HEALTH		
☐	Medical records	
☐	Immunization records	
☐	Health insurance cards	
☐	List of prescriptions	
☐	Living will	
☐	Healthcare power of attorney	
MONEY		
☐	Bank statements	
☐	Pay stubs	
☐	Tax returns	
☐	Benefit letters (SNAP, TANF, WIC)	
☐	Loan papers	
☐	Credit card statements	
☐	Retirement account information	

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✓	Document	Where I keep it
HOME AND CAR		
☐	Lease or deed	
☐	Utility account numbers	
☐	Car title	
☐	Registration	
☐	Car insurance	
☐	Renters or home insurance	
SCHOOL AND WORK		
☐	Diploma or GED	
☐	Transcripts	
☐	Certificates and licenses	
☐	Résumé	
☐	List of references	
☐	Military records (DD-214)	
FAMILY		
☐	Children’s birth certificates and Social Security cards	
☐	School records	
☐	Immunization records	
☐	Custody or child support orders	
☐	Childcare contacts	
☐	Will	
☐	Power of attorney	
OTHER		
☐		
☐		
☐		
☐		
☐		

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Project Title: My Self-Advocacy, Workplace Readiness, & Family Advocacy Plan

OBJECTIVE:
Students will develop a personalized plan to enhance their self-advocacy skills while preparing for success in the workplace, job searching, balancing family responsibilities, and advocating for their children and families in schools and the community.

STEPS:

1 Self-Reflection Journal
- Write about a challenge they face balancing home life, job responsibilities, job searching, and family needs.
- Identify specific areas where self-advocacy could help, such as requesting flexible work arrangements, negotiating salary, accessing workplace benefits, or advocating for their children's education and well-being.

2 Research & Resources
- Find at least three resources (job search assistance programs, workplace policies, school programs, community services, or parent support groups).
- Summarize how each resource can support workplace readiness, career success, and family well-being.

3 Communication Strategy
- Draft an email or script for a conversation with an employer, hiring manager, teacher, school administrator, or community organization to request support, accommodations, or services.
- Peer review and practice delivering the request.

4 Job Search & Workplace Readiness
- Identify job search challenges (e.g., flexible work schedules, childcare needs, skill development).
- Develop a strategy for advocating for their needs in resumes, cover letters, and interviews.
- Research companies that support working parents and review employee benefits such as childcare assistance or remote work options.
- Learn about professional etiquette, workplace expectations, and strategies for career advancement.

5 Advocating for Children & Family in Schools & the Community
- Identify challenges their children face in school (e.g., learning support, special education, extracurricular access).
- Learn how to communicate effectively with teachers and school administrators.
- Explore ways to get involved in community programs that support parents and families.
- Research laws and policies that protect parents' and children's rights in education and community resources.

6 Advocacy Action Plan
- Outline 3-5 concrete steps they will take in the next month to improve their self-advocacy, workplace readiness, and family advocacy.

7 Presentation or Reflection
- Share key takeaways in a brief written reflection or informal discussion.
- Discuss how self-advocacy in work, school, and community settings will impact their personal and professional growth.

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Self-Advocacy & Self-Determination Checklist

1 Knowing Yourself & Your Needs

- [ ] I know my strengths and what I am good at.
- [ ] I know what kind of job I want and what works for my family.
- [ ] I understand the problems I might face (childcare, transportation, job skills).
- [ ] I know my rights as a worker (fair pay, time off, workplace rules).
- [ ] I can speak up for what I need at work.
- [ ] I take care of my health and well-being while looking for a job.

2 Job Search & Getting Ready for Work

- [ ] I know where to look for jobs.
- [ ] I have a resume that shows my skills and experience.
- [ ] I can talk about why I would be good for a job.
- [ ] I practice answering interview questions.
- [ ] I am ready to explain work gaps or changes in my career.
- [ ] I know how to ask for better pay or hours.
- [ ] I have a way to look professional online (LinkedIn or social media).
- [ ] I know where to get help with job searching (job centers, career programs).

3 Balancing Work & Family

- [ ] I look for jobs that fit my family's needs (flexible hours, remote work).
- [ ] I have a plan for childcare when I start working.
- [ ] I know my rights for family leave and sick time.
- [ ] I know how to manage stress and balance work with family.
- [ ] I set clear work and home boundaries.
- [ ] I have a backup plan if my child gets sick or something unexpected happens.
- [ ] I talk with my family about my job plans.

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4 Making Good Decisions

- [ ] I make choices that help me and my family.
- [ ] I know where to go for help when I have a problem.
- [ ] I can ask for fair pay and good working conditions.
- [ ] I am comfortable talking about my schedule, pay, or job duties.
- [ ] I adjust my job search if things are not working.
- [ ] I feel confident making decisions, even when it's hard.

5 Finding Support & Connections

- [ ] I have people I can ask for help and advice.
- [ ] I stay connected with job groups or community programs.
- [ ] I feel comfortable asking others about job openings.
- [ ] I reach out to old coworkers, bosses, or friends for job leads.
- [ ] I try to meet new people at job fairs or events.
- [ ] I talk to other parents about balancing work and family.

6 Knowing My Rights & Money Management

- [ ] I know my rights for fair pay, time off, and workplace rules.
- [ ] I have a plan to manage my money while looking for a job.
- [ ] I know about programs that help parents with money (childcare, food, housing).
- [ ] I understand what comes with a job (pay, healthcare, vacation time).
- [ ] I know about taxes and other costs that come with working.
- [ ] I know how to report unfair treatment at work.

7 Learning & Growing

- [ ] I am open to learning new skills.
- [ ] I ask for feedback to improve my job search.
- [ ] I set small goals to keep moving forward.
- [ ] I use free classes or training programs to build new skills.
- [ ] I stay updated on job trends and opportunities.
- [ ] I work on improving my speaking and communication skills.
- [ ] I take care of myself and celebrate my progress.

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Self-Advocacy Communication Organizer

1 Identify the Need

What do I need?

(Be specific about what information or support you're seeking.)

Why do I need this information or support?

(Explain the importance or purpose of your request.)

2 Know Your Rights or Entitlements

What are my rights or entitlements?

(What laws, policies, or guidelines apply to your situation? Consider any protections you may have.)

What support or accommodations am I entitled to?

(This could relate to school, work, or personal situations.)

3 Prepare Your Message

Who do I need to talk to?

(Identify the person or organization that can help with your request.)

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What do I need to say?

(Prepare a clear, direct message to explain your needs.)

4 Ask Clear Questions

What do I want to know or ask for?

(Be specific in your request so that the person you're speaking to understands.)

How will I ask for clarification if I don’t understand?

(Plan a phrase to ask for more information, e.g., "Could you explain that again?" or "Can you provide an example?")

5 Active Listening and Response

How will I actively listen to the response?

(This is about being present and attentive, avoiding interruptions.)

What questions might I ask to clarify the response?

(Consider follow-up questions based on the answer you receive.)

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6 Confirm the Outcome

What is the next step?

(Clarify any action items, deadlines, or follow-up steps.)

How will I follow up if necessary?

(Write down any plans for following up or checking in.)

7 Reflection

How did the conversation go?

(Reflect on how comfortable you were, if you got the information you needed, and what went well.)

What will I do differently next time?

(Consider what you might adjust in your approach next time.)

This graphic organizer helps structure communication, especially when advocating for specific information. It keeps the conversation focused and ensures all steps—preparation, asking questions, listening, and following up—are taken into account.

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Self-Advocacy for Adult Learners

What is Self-Advocacy?

Self-advocacy means standing up for yourself, making your own decisions, and communicating your needs and desires. It's about understanding your rights, knowing how to ask for what you need, and seeking out opportunities that help you succeed.

Why is Self-Advocacy Important?

- **Empowerment:** You take control of your own life and decisions.
- **Confidence:** It boosts your confidence when you speak up for your needs.
- **Better Communication:** You'll be able to effectively express your thoughts, feelings, and needs in personal and professional settings.
- **Advancement:** Helps you move forward in your career or education by ensuring you're getting the resources you need.

Key Components of Self-Advocacy

1. Know Yourself:

- Understand your strengths and areas of improvement.
- Recognize your needs, challenges, and preferences (learning style, working hours, health considerations, etc.).
- Keep track of your goals and progress.

2. Know Your Rights:

- Learn about your rights in education, the workplace, and society.
- Be aware of any legal protections or accommodations you may be entitled to.
- If you're unsure of your rights, ask for help from trusted advisors or organizations.

3. Communicate Clearly:

- Be direct and clear about your needs and requests.
- Practice active listening: make sure you fully understand others' responses.
- Be respectful and polite, even when disagreeing.

4. Set Goals and Make a Plan:

- Identify what you need to achieve and why.
- Break big goals into smaller, manageable steps.
- Regularly evaluate your progress and adjust your plan as needed.

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How to Practice Self-Advocacy

1. Identify Your Needs:

- Example: If you struggle with balancing work and study, ask for a flexible schedule or support to prioritize your tasks.

2. Gather Information:

- Collect information about the situation, whether it's understanding your course requirements, job expectations, or health needs.

3. Practice Speaking Up:

- Role-play with a trusted friend or mentor to practice how you might ask for accommodations, express concerns, or make requests.

4. Use "I" Statements:

- Express your feelings and needs using "I" statements like "I feel…" or "I need…" rather than making demands or blaming others.
- Example: "I feel overwhelmed when there's a lot of information at once, and I would appreciate having time to process it."

5. Be Persistent but Respectful:

- Don't give up if your first request isn't granted.
- Follow up and ask for clarification when needed.

Common Scenarios in Self-Advocacy

1. In Education:

- Requesting accommodations (extra time for exams, access to materials in different formats).
- Asking for clarification on assignments or deadlines.
- Seeking additional support, like tutoring or counseling.

2. In the Workplace:

- Asking for flexible hours, remote work, or a quieter environment.
- Expressing dissatisfaction with workload or management.
- Negotiating for a raise, promotion, or professional development opportunities.

3. In Daily Life:

- Seeking medical accommodations or assistance.
- Managing personal relationships by setting clear boundaries.
- Asking for help in social situations.

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Overcoming Barriers to Self-Advocacy

Fear of Rejection or Conflict:

- Remind yourself that your needs are valid, and it's okay to speak up.
- Practice in low-pressure situations before tackling harder conversations.

Lack of Knowledge:

- Research your rights, available resources, and ways to communicate effectively.
- Don't be afraid to ask for help from someone who is knowledgeable about your situation.

Lack of Confidence:

- Start small—practice with people you trust.
- Reflect on past successes where you've advocated for yourself and use those as confidence boosters.

Tips for Effective Self-Advocacy

- Stay calm and collected—take a deep breath before speaking.
- Be specific about what you need or want.
- Use positive body language (make eye contact, speak clearly, and stand tall).
- Keep a record of important conversations (emails, notes) in case you need to follow up later.
- Be patient—change may take time, but persistence pays off.

Resources for Support

- **Local Advocacy Groups:** These can assist you in understanding your rights and help with specific needs (e.g., disability services, workplace advocacy).
- **Counselors or Advisors:** Seek guidance from mentors or counselors who specialize in supporting adult learners.
- **Online Communities:** Many online forums and websites offer tips and support for self-advocacy.

Remember:

Self-advocacy is about respecting both your needs and the needs of others. By speaking up and asking for support, you are empowering yourself to thrive.

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Self-Advocacy Resource Tracking Chart

Use this chart to track important resources as you research and make calls. Fill in details to stay organized and ensure follow-ups.

Category (Work, School, Community, Family, etc.)	Resource Name	Contact Info / Website	Person Spoken To	Key Information / Services Offered	Next Steps / Follow-Up Needed

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Six Steps to Asking for Help

START

1

Name the problem.

What is going on? Write it in one sentence.

2

Know why you need help.

What is getting in your way?

3

Find who can help.

A supervisor, teacher, caseworker, family member or community group. List two.

4

Ask early.

Don't wait until it's a crisis. When will you ask?

5

Ask calmly and clearly.

Say what you need, be polite and stay open to answers.

What I will say:

6

Follow up.

If the first try doesn't work, ask again or try someone else.

Who is next?

GOAL

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Self-Advocacy Role-Play Scenarios

Family & Personal Self-Advocacy Scenarios

1 Setting Boundaries with a Family Member — In-Person

A relative constantly criticizes your parenting choices. You need to have a respectful conversation to set clear boundaries.

2 Addressing a Conflict with a Teenager — In-Person

Your teenager has been staying out late without checking in. You need to express concerns, set expectations, and agree on a solution.

3 Asking a Family Member for Support — Phone or In-Person

You need help with childcare, transportation, or finances, but your family member has been reluctant. You need to make a clear and reasonable request.

4 Handling an Unfair Family Obligation — In-Person

You are always expected to take care of certain family responsibilities, and it is becoming overwhelming. You need to speak up and request a fairer division of tasks.

5 Advocating for Yourself at a Family Gathering — In-Person

A family member makes an inappropriate or hurtful comment about your lifestyle, career, or parenting. You need to stand up for yourself without escalating the situation.

School & Child Advocacy Scenarios

6 Requesting an IEP or 504 Plan for Your Child — Email

Your child needs additional academic support due to a learning disability. You need to email the school to formally request an evaluation.

7 Reporting Bullying at School — Phone

Your child has been bullied, and previous reports to the school have not led to action. You need to call the principal and demand a concrete response.

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8 Disputing an Unfair School Disciplinary Action Email or In-Person

Your child was disciplined for something you believe was unfair. You need to request a meeting to discuss the situation with the school administration.

9 Requesting a Meeting with a Teacher Email or Phone

Your child is struggling in a particular class, and you want to discuss concerns with their teacher. You need to email or call to schedule a meeting.

10 Addressing a Safety Concern at School Phone or In-Person

You recently noticed a safety issue at your child's school (e.g., unsafe playground, lack of supervision). You need to bring it to the administration's attention.

Job Searching Self-Advocacy Scenarios

11 Requesting a Professional Reference Phone or Email

You are applying for a job and need a professional reference from a former employer. You need to ask them for a strong recommendation.

12 Following Up on a Job Interview Email

You had an interview and haven't heard back. You need to send a professional follow-up email to check on the hiring process.

13 Negotiating Salary for a Job Offer In-Person or Phone

You received a job offer, but the salary is lower than expected. You need to advocate for a higher salary or better benefits.

14 Asking for More Details About a Job Offer Email or Phone

You received a job offer, but some details (schedule, benefits, responsibilities) are unclear. You need to ask for clarification before accepting.

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15 Requesting Feedback After a Job Rejection Email

You applied for a job but didn't get it. You want to email the hiring manager to ask for constructive feedback to improve in the future.

Workplace Readiness & Self-Advocacy Scenarios

16 Requesting a Workplace Accommodation Phone or Email

You need a reasonable workplace accommodation (e.g., flexible schedule, ergonomic chair, extra training). You need to advocate for your needs professionally.

17 Addressing an Issue with a Supervisor Email or In-Person

You feel you are being treated unfairly at work (e.g., excessive workload, unclear expectations). You need to communicate your concerns with your supervisor.

18 Asking for a Promotion or Raise In-Person

You have been excelling at your job and believe you deserve a promotion or raise. You need to have a professional conversation with your manager.

19 Responding to Unfair Criticism at Work In-Person

A colleague or supervisor has unfairly criticized your work. You need to address the issue calmly and professionally.

20 Reporting Workplace Harassment or Discrimination Phone, Email, or In-Person

You have experienced or witnessed harassment/discrimination at work. You need to report it to HR while protecting yourself.

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Self-Advocacy: Worksheet 1 – Making a Plan

Being clear about what you want to achieve is an essential first step in self-advocacy and this worksheet can help you to think clearly and make a plan.

What is the issue? What would you like to change?

What is your goal? What result would you like to achieve?

What information do you need in order to achieve your goal? Where can you get that information?

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What support might you need to achieve your goal? Where can you get that support?

Who are the decision-makers that you need to influence to achieve your goal? What actions can you take? Who do you need to speak to?

I will call/meet with/write to _____ by the following date: _____

If the person does not resolve the situation by the following date _____

then I will call/meet with/write to _____

Documentation that I will need:

What is the backup plan if this strategy doesn't work?

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Self-Advocacy Worksheet 1, part 2 – Making a Plan

Remember, you could have a different plan for each goal.

What is my goal?: _____

ACTION What needs to be done? What steps am I going to try?	DATES Important dates: appointments, meetings, deadline	WHO Who do I need to speak to/meet with? Who's getting back to me?	PROGRESS What have I done so far?

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Self-Advocacy Worksheet for Parents

Name: _____ **Date:** _____

1. Understanding Self-Advocacy in Your Life

What does self-advocacy mean to you as a parent, both personally and professionally?

(Consider how self-advocacy plays a role in balancing your family responsibilities and work, as well as in ensuring your needs are met.)

_____

_____

_____

2. Advocating for Your Needs as a Parent

What are some of the key needs you have as a parent that may require advocacy?

(Think about your personal needs for self-care, time management, or support, as well as your children's needs, such as in education or healthcare.)

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

How can advocating for these needs improve your well-being and ability to care for your family?

_____

_____

_____

_____

3. Advocating for Your Professional Needs

In your professional life, what needs do you have that you may need to advocate for?

(For example: flexible working hours, time off for family commitments, career advancement, etc.)

1. _____
2. _____

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Why is it important to advocate for these needs in your professional life?

(Consider the impact on your career, work-life balance, and long-term goals.)

4. Balancing Family and Work

Think about a time when you needed to balance work and family responsibilities. How did you advocate for yourself during that time?

(For example, did you request a flexible work schedule, delegate tasks at home, or ask for help from a colleague or family member?)

What could you do differently next time to better advocate for both your personal and professional needs?

5. Role-Playing a Self-Advocacy Situation in Your Personal Life

Imagine you need to ask for help at home (e.g., more support from your partner, time for yourself, help with children's activities). Write a short script for how you might approach this conversation.

You:

Partner/Family Member:

You:

Partner/Family Member:

You:

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6. Role-Playing a Self-Advocacy Situation in Your Professional Life

Imagine you need to request flexibility or support at work (e.g., a change in your schedule, the ability to work from home, or time off for family reasons). Write a short script for how you might communicate this need with your supervisor or HR department.

You: _____

Supervisor/HR: _____

You: _____

Supervisor/HR: _____

You: _____

7. Identifying Potential Barriers to Self-Advocacy

What challenges might you face when advocating for your needs at home or at work?

(Consider personal feelings like guilt, fear of judgment, or external challenges like company policies or family dynamics.)

_____

_____

_____

How can you overcome these challenges to advocate more effectively for yourself and your family?

(Write about practical steps you can take, like building confidence, seeking support, or improving communication.)

_____

_____

_____

8. Setting Goals for Self-Advocacy

What is one action you can take in the next week to advocate for your needs—either at home or at work?

(Choose one situation where you can improve your self-advocacy and describe the steps you'll take.)

_____

_____

_____

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Why is this action important for you and your family?

9. Supporting Your Children Through Self-Advocacy

How can you teach your children the importance of self-advocacy?

(Consider how you might model self-advocacy for your children, whether through communication, teaching them to ask for help, or empowering them to express their needs.)

10. Reflection on Your Self-Advocacy Journey

After completing this worksheet, how do you feel about advocating for yourself as a parent, both personally and professionally?

(Reflect on your confidence and the steps you plan to take moving forward.)

Final Thought:

Self-advocacy is a key skill for maintaining a healthy balance between your personal, family, and professional life. By being proactive in expressing your needs, you can create a positive environment where both you and your family can thrive!

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Getting Ready to Speak Up

At Work or School

Speaking up goes better when you plan what to say.

THE SITUATION

Who do I need to talk to? _____

What do I need from them? _____

When and where will we talk? _____

PLAN WHAT TO SAY

1. What is working well right now?

_____

_____

2. What is not working?

_____

_____

3. What have I already tried?

_____

_____

4. What would make the biggest difference?

_____

_____

5. What am I willing to do in return?

_____

_____

6. What will I do if the answer is no?

_____

_____

My best outcome

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

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Getting Ready to Speak Up

For a Job Interview

Speaking up goes better when you plan what to say.

THE SITUATION

What job am I interviewing for? _____

Who will I meet? _____

What do I know about the company? _____

PLAN WHAT TO SAY

1. **What skills make me a good fit?**

2. **What do I need from this job (pay, hours, schedule)?**

3. **What questions will I ask them?**

4. **What concern might they ask about, and how will I answer?**

5. **What would make me turn down an offer?**

6. **What do I want them to remember about me?**

My best outcome

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Getting Ready to Speak Up

When Negotiating

Speaking up goes better when you plan what to say.

THE SITUATION

What am I asking for (pay, schedule, duties)? _____

Who decides? _____

What do they care about? _____

PLAN WHAT TO SAY

1. What is fair pay for this job in my area?

_____

_____

2. What is my best result?

_____

_____

3. What is the least I can accept?

_____

_____

4. What can I be flexible on?

_____

_____

5. What proof shows I deserve this?

_____

_____

6. What will I say first?

_____

_____

My best outcome

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

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Self-Assessment: Self-Advocacy for Job-Seeking Parents

This self-assessment helps you evaluate your ability to advocate for yourself, your child, your health, and your mental well-being while balancing job seeking and parenting. Answer each question honestly using the following scale:

☐ **Always** (3 points) ☐ **Sometimes** (2 points) ☐ **Rarely/Never** (1 point)

INSTRUCTIONS:

- Read each statement and mark the score that best describes you.
- At the end of each section, total your points in the 'Section Score' box.
- Add up all section scores to get your final score.

Understanding Yourself & Your Needs

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I know my strengths and what I am good at.	☐	☐	☐
I can clearly explain the type of job I want.	☐	☐	☐
I understand the challenges I may face.	☐	☐	☐
I am aware of my rights as a worker.	☐	☐	☐
I take care of my mental and physical health during my job search.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

Job Search & Employment Readiness

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I have a strong resume.	☐	☐	☐
I know how to search for jobs.	☐	☐	☐
I practice answering interview questions.	☐	☐	☐
I can explain job gaps confidently.	☐	☐	☐
I am comfortable negotiating salary and benefits.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

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Balancing Work & Family

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I look for jobs that fit my family's needs.	☐	☐	☐
I have a childcare plan for when I start working.	☐	☐	☐
I know my rights for family leave.	☐	☐	☐
I set clear work-home boundaries.	☐	☐	☐
I have a backup plan for family emergencies.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

Making Decisions & Problem-Solving

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I make informed decisions that benefit both my career and family.	☐	☐	☐
I know where to get help when I face job search challenges.	☐	☐	☐
I feel confident negotiating my work schedule, salary, or job duties.	☐	☐	☐
I adjust my job search strategy when needed.	☐	☐	☐
I feel comfortable making difficult decisions under pressure.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

Building a Support System

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I have a network of friends, family, or mentors who support me.	☐	☐	☐
I connect with job support groups, online communities, or career programs.	☐	☐	☐
I reach out to former colleagues, bosses, or contacts for job leads.	☐	☐	☐
I attend job fairs, networking events, or workshops when possible.	☐	☐	☐
I ask for help when I need it, whether for job searching or family support.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

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Understanding My Rights & Finances

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I know my rights regarding workplace discrimination and fair pay.	☐	☐	☐
I have a financial plan while looking for a job.	☐	☐	☐
I know about resources that provide childcare, food, or housing assistance.	☐	☐	☐
I understand the benefits of different jobs.	☐	☐	☐
I know how to report unfair treatment at work.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 15**

Advocating for My Child

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I know my child's needs at home, school, and in the community.	☐	☐	☐
I can speak up for my child's education, health, and safety.	☐	☐	☐
I know my rights as a parent in my child's school.	☐	☐	☐
I make sure my child has access to the resources they need.	☐	☐	☐
I talk with teachers, doctors, and community members to support my child's success.	☐	☐	☐
I teach my child how to speak up for themselves in school and social settings.	☐	☐	☐
I help my child understand and express their feelings and needs.	☐	☐	☐
I look for programs or services that support working parents and children.	☐	☐	☐
I feel confident making decisions about my child's care and education.	☐	☐	☐
I make time to listen to my child's concerns and help them solve problems.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 30**

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Advocating for Health Needs

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I make my health a priority and take care of my physical and mental well-being.	☐	☐	☐
I speak up to doctors and healthcare providers when I have questions or concerns.	☐	☐	☐
I know my rights when it comes to healthcare access and workplace accommodations.	☐	☐	☐
I make sure my child receives the medical care they need.	☐	☐	☐
I seek out low-cost or free healthcare options if needed.	☐	☐	☐
I ask for workplace accommodations if I have a health condition that affects my job.	☐	☐	☐
I teach my child how to speak up about their own health needs.	☐	☐	☐
I keep track of important health documents for myself and my child.	☐	☐	☐
I know where to find resources for mental health support.	☐	☐	☐
I encourage healthy habits for myself and my family.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 30**

Advocating for Mental Health

Question	Always (3)	Sometimes (2)	Rarely/Never (1)
I acknowledge when I am feeling stressed, overwhelmed, or anxious.	☐	☐	☐
I seek professional help when needed.	☐	☐	☐
I make time for self-care and stress management activities.	☐	☐	☐
I set boundaries to protect my emotional and mental well-being.	☐	☐	☐
I talk openly with my child about mental health and emotions.	☐	☐	☐
I encourage my child to express their feelings and seek help when needed.	☐	☐	☐
I educate myself on mental health resources available to me and my family.	☐	☐	☐
I know my rights regarding mental health accommodations at work.	☐	☐	☐
I practice positive coping skills to manage anxiety and stress.	☐	☐	☐
I support my child's mental health by creating a safe and supportive home environment.	☐	☐	☐

Section Score: _____ **/ 30**

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Final Score Calculation

Section	Total Points Possible	Your Score
Understanding Yourself & Your Needs	15	
Job Search & Employment Readiness	15	
Balancing Work & Family	15	
Making Decisions & Problem-Solving	15	
Building a Support System	15	
Understanding My Rights & Finances	15	
Advocating for My Child	30	
Advocating for Health Needs	30	
Advocating for Mental Health	30	
TOTAL SCORE	**180**	

Notes: _____

Scoring Guide

150-180 points – Strong Advocate
You are confident in advocating for yourself, your child, your health, and your mental well-being while balancing job seeking and parenting.

100-149 points – Growing Advocate
You have some good self-advocacy skills but may need to strengthen certain areas.

60-99 points – Needs Improvement
You may struggle with self-advocacy in one or more areas. Consider seeking support and training.

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Helping Children Develop Self-Advocacy Skills at Each Stage of Life

Introduction

Self-advocacy is an essential life skill that empowers children to understand their needs, express themselves effectively, and make informed decisions. Developing self-advocacy skills at each stage of a child's life fosters confidence, independence, and resilience. This guide outlines ways to nurture self-advocacy from early childhood through adolescence.

Age Group	Key Strategies	
Early Childhood (Ages 3-6)	• **Encourage Communication:** Teach children to express their needs and emotions using words rather than gestures. • **Model Advocacy:** Demonstrate how to ask for help or express needs.	• **Offer Choices:** Allow children to make simple decisions, such as choosing between two snack options. • **Validate Feelings:** Acknowledge their emotions and guide them in expressing themselves appropriately.
Middle Childhood (Ages 7-12)	• **Teach Problem-Solving:** Encourage children to think through challenges and brainstorm possible solutions. • **Encourage Self-Expression:** Support children in voicing their opinions in discussions.	• **Promote Responsibility:** Assign age-appropriate tasks to foster independence and accountability. • **Introduce Self-Reflection:** Help children recognize their strengths and areas where they may need support.
Adolescence (Ages 13-18)	• **Develop Decision-Making Skills:** Provide opportunities for teens to make more significant choices. • **Support Identity Development:** Encourage teens to explore their interests and set goals.	• **Encourage Self-Advocacy in School:** Teach students how to communicate with teachers. • **Prepare for Adulthood:** Guide teenagers in learning essential life skills like managing finances and seeking employment.

Conclusion

Self-advocacy is a lifelong skill that can be nurtured from a young age. By providing children with opportunities to express themselves, make decisions, and seek support, parents and educators can empower them to become confident and independent individuals. Supporting self-advocacy at each stage of development ensures that children grow into adults who can effectively advocate for their own needs and aspirations.

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What Is Self-Advocacy?

Self-advocacy means standing up for yourself and your family by knowing what you need and asking for it.



Speak up for yourself

Say what you need, clearly and calmly.



Know your rights

At work, at school and with benefits.



Get the facts

Find out how things work before you decide.



Build your support team

People and programs who have your back.



Solve problems

Look for options, pick one, try it.



Ask for help early

Before a small problem becomes a big one.

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Phone Call Notes Template

Date: _____ **Time:** _____

Call From/To: _____

Contact Name: _____

Company/Organization: _____

CALL DETAILS

Reason for Call / Topic:

_____

_____

Key Points Discussed:

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Questions Asked:

_____

_____

_____

Decisions Made / Agreements:

_____

_____

_____

_____

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ACTION ITEMS

☐ _____

(Assigned to: _____ Due: _____)

☐ _____

(Assigned to: _____ Due: _____)

☐ _____

(Assigned to: _____ Due: _____)

FOLLOW-UP NEEDED

Next Steps:

_____

_____

_____

Next Call/Meeting Scheduled:

_____

_____

ADDITIONAL NOTES

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

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